

# STRIKING THE RIGHT NOTES

One of the world's greatest conductors tells all about his love, life, and passion for music in an utterly frank autobiography



**THE SCORE OF MY LIFE**  
by ZUBIN MEHTA  
As told to RENATE GRAFIN MATUSCHKA  
Lotus/Roli  
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■ By Kaverie Bamzai

The arms akimbo, the baton making an invisible arc, the shock of curly hair emitting an almost electric charge, the eyes closed as if in a trance. Some pictures never age. Neither do their subjects. At 72, as he sits in Oslo, speaking from a hotel room, his call interrupted by a hotel attendant who wants his laundry, Zubin Mehta will always be the young maestro, captured for posterity in black and white—the image reproduced a million times to underscore his celebrity, much before the word became synonymous with the LiRos and the JLos.

But then, the great conductor has always been a walking advertisement for cultural synthesis. A classical musician with the air of a rock star, a citizen of the world with an Indian passport, a purist with a love of the good life, Mehta has been an ambassador of the country longer than most countries have existed. And unlike most great artists, he is also extraordinarily frank in his autobiography, *The Score of My Life* (first written in German in 2006). To get the gossip bits out of the way first, yes, he has four children, two out of wedlock, one in between his two marriages and one, much to his abiding regret, during his long and enduring marriage to Nancy Kovack. "It will be 40 years next year," he says. "She taught me to afford things, and I don't mean only in material terms," he adds. It's difficult to imagine him as a cuddly grandpa, but he insists his relationship with his children is close, even with Ori, the

18-year-old born in Israel, who learnt English in order to converse with his famous father. And yes, even more extraordinarily, his first wife, Carmen, did marry his younger brother and has lived happily ever after with him.

Ultimately, the book, as the life it encapsulates, is about music, and as Mehta waxes eloquent about it, there is just a glimpse of the passion that must have driven his violinist father and then, him to seek a life dedicated to it. There were times when he was starved of funds and he says how he once approached Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit, who in turn asked her brother, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru to sponsor his trip to the US. Difficult to imagine that sort of interest from today's politicians, you say. "Well I was extraordinarily close to the family. I was at school with the Hutheesingh boy, who married Nehru's sister Krishna. And I sat at Mrs Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit's feet at Indira Gandhi's funeral," he says.

His has been a life replete with an-

## EXCERPT

My acquaintance with actors like Gregory Peck, Sophia Loren, Yves Montand and Danny Kaye should not lead to the assumption that I am interested in knowing the who's who of Hollywood. I have repeatedly been accused of having a superficial interest in stars from the world of cinema and entertainment. Some people might prefer not to believe this, but famous film stars are often declared fans of music. Sophia Loren has a very gifted son, Carlo Ponti, who is well on his way to becoming an established conductor. A particularly close friend, Louis Jourdan, can immediately sing quotations from Schoenberg's *Gurrelieder*, recite Shakespeare's *Henry the Fifth* or break into a variety of Frank Sinatra songs.

**ANIMATED ARTIST:**  
Mehta conducting an anti-Vietnam war concert



ecdotes, from a rivalry with conductor Georg Solti to a fight with composer Igor Stravinsky to a deep friendship with the talented cellist Jacqueline Du Pre who died in 1978 from multiple sclerosis. The stories trip so eloquently off his tongue that you're sure there's another book somewhere. He speaks animatedly of how he called his friend textile entrepreneur Nusli Wadia when he saw him sitting with his mother, next to Pervez Musharraf, at the Lahore one day match in 2004. "I love good old-fashioned Test matches. I can't abide by the Twenty20 *maramari*," he says, adding proudly that his homes in Los Angeles and Florence are equipped with satellite channels required for him to watch his